

Forests and Woodlands



FROM THE EVERGREEN forests of the north to the broad-leaved woodlands further south, European forests provide a rich habitat for birds. Tree trunks and branches are safe nesting places and tree leaves, nuts, and berries are good to eat.

Insects and small creatures living on the trees and woodland floor are also food for birds. The northern forests are generally darker and colder than those further south, which have a greater variety of food and nesting places. Unfortunately, many of Europe's forests are now threatened by pollution and deforestation.

European forest and woodland birds have to arrange their lives around the seasons. In spring and summer, they nest and rear their young; in fall, they eat as much as possible to build up stores of fat in their bodies; and in winter, they may fly south to warmer places or roam widely through the forest in search of food.

Eurasian jay

The harsh, screeching call of the Eurasian jay can often be heard in broad-leaved woodlands, especially in the spring, when birds chase each other noisily through the trees as part of their courtship display. Jays feed on acorns, which they often carry for long distances, and then bury to eat during the cold winter months. Acorns that are not eaten grow into new oak trees, helping the woodlands spread. Jays also eat other nuts, berries, worms, spiders, and the eggs and young of other birds.

Crest is often raised, making the bird's head look like a square shape.



Eurasian jay
(*Garrulus glandarius*)
Length: 1 ft 3 in (37 cm)

Eurasian sparrowhawk

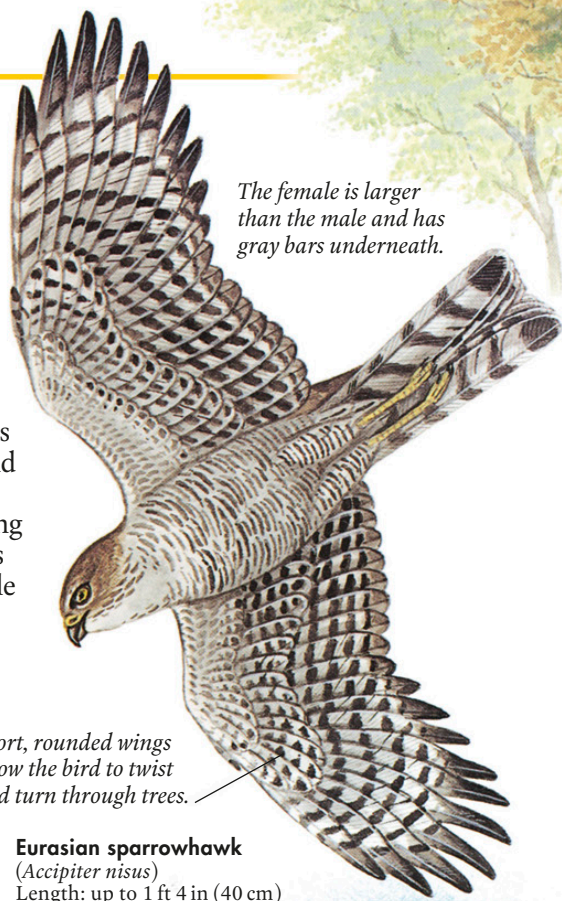
The agile sparrowhawk makes swift, surprise attacks on blue tits and other small birds. They stand very little chance of escaping its needle-sharp talons. Before eating its prey, the sparrowhawk plucks off the bird's feathers. The female tears up food that the male has caught to feed to the young.



Blue tits

Short, rounded wings allow the bird to twist and turn through trees.

Eurasian sparrowhawk
(*Accipiter nisus*)
Length: up to 1 ft 4 in (40 cm)



The female is larger than the male and has gray bars underneath.



Crossbills nest and feed high in the treetops of coniferous forests. They pull seeds from pine cones and rarely venture down to the forest floor.

0 100 200 300 km
0 100 200 miles

ATLANTIC OCEAN

NORTH SEA

BRITISH ISLES

EUROPE

BALTIC SEA

Elbe

Rhine

Oder

Vistula

Loire

ALPS

MEDITERRANEAN SEA

CARPATHIAN MTS

	GREAT GRAY OWL		EURASIAN SPARROWHAWK
	BOHEMIAN WAXWING		EURASIAN JAY
	EURASIAN GREEN WOODPECKER		LONG-TAILED TIT
	WESTERN CAPERCAILLIE		